

1 Norm Approximation

Let $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times n}$, $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$. The objective is to minimize the residual vector $\mathbf{r} = \mathbf{Ax} - \mathbf{b}$.
 The general problem is formulated as,

$$\min_{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n} \|\mathbf{Ax} - \mathbf{b}\|.$$

Definition 1.1 (ℓ_1 norm): For $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^m$, ℓ_1 norm is defined as

$$\|\mathbf{y}\|_1 = \sum_{i=1}^m |y_i|$$

Definition 1.2 (ℓ_2 norm): For $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^m$, ℓ_2 norm is defined as

$$\|\mathbf{y}\|_2 = \left(\sum_{i=1}^m y_i^2 \right)^{1/2}$$

Definition 1.3 (ℓ_∞ norm): For $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^m$, ℓ_∞ norm is defined as

$$\|\mathbf{y}\|_\infty = \max_{1 \leq i \leq m} |y_i|$$

1.1 Penalty Functions

1.1.1 Norm Based ($p = 1, 2, \infty$)

$$\|\cdot\|_1, \|\cdot\|_2, \|\cdot\|_\infty.$$

1.1.2 Dead Zone Linear

Functions of the form, for $r \in \mathbb{R}^n$,

$$\sum_i \phi(r_i),$$

where

$$\phi(r) = \max\{|r| - a, 0\}.$$

1.1.3 Log Barrier

$$\phi(u) = \begin{cases} -\log(1 - u^2), & |u| < 1 \\ \infty, & |u| \geq 1 \end{cases}$$

1.1.4 Huber Penalty

1.2 Moreau Envelope

Definition 1.4 (Moreau Envelope): Given $f : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, we have the Moreau Envelope as

$$f_u(\mathbf{x}) = \min_{\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n} \left\{ f(\mathbf{y}) + \frac{1}{2u} \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\|^2 \right\}.$$

1.2.1 Properties of Moreau Envelope

1. $f_u(\mathbf{x})$ is differentiable if f is continuous. Further, the derivative is continuous.
2. $f_u(\mathbf{x})$ is defined for all $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, even when f is not.
3. $f_u(\mathbf{x})$ is convex whenever f is convex.
4. If x^* is the unique minimizer of f , then it is the unique minimizer of $f_u(\mathbf{x})$

Remark 1.5: $f_u(\mathbf{x})$ is convex, since it is the min over one variable of a jointly convex function.

Remark 1.6: $f_u(\mathbf{x})$ is continuously smooth.

Remark 1.7:

$$\text{epi} f_u(x) = \text{epi} f(x) \oplus \text{epi} \left(\frac{1}{2u} \|x\|^2 \right)$$

Remark 1.8: x^* is a minima of f if and only if x^* is a minima of f_u .

Remark 1.9:

$$\nabla f_u(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{1}{u} (1 - \text{prox}_u(x)),$$

where,

$$\text{prox}_u(x) = \arg \min_{\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n} \left\{ f(\mathbf{y}) + \frac{1}{2u} \|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}\|^2 \right\}.$$

2 Epigraphs

TODO: complete this

Duality

Supporting Hyperplane Theorem

Definition 2.1 (Conjugate of a function): Let $f : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. The conjugate $f^* : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ of f is defined as,

$$f^*(\mathbf{y}) = \sup_{\mathbf{x} \in \text{dom} f} (\mathbf{y}^T \mathbf{x} - f(\mathbf{x})).$$

Remark 2.2: The conjugate of f is also called Legendre transform, polar of f , Fenchel dual.

Remark 2.3: f^* is convex, irrespective of f .

Remark 2.4:

$$-f^*(0) = \min_{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n} f(\mathbf{x})$$

Remark 2.5: *Fenchel Young inequality*

$$f(\mathbf{x}) + f^*(\mathbf{m}) \geq \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x}$$

2.1 Recovering f from f^*

Definition 2.6 (Biconjugate): Let $f^* : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R} \cup \{+\infty\}$ be the conjugate of a function $f : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R} \cup \{+\infty\}$. The **biconjugate** $f^{**} : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R} \cup \{+\infty\}$ is defined as the conjugate of f^* ,

$$f^{**}(\mathbf{x}) = (f^*)^*(\mathbf{x}) = \sup_{\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n} (\mathbf{y}^T \mathbf{x} - f^*(\mathbf{y})).$$

Remark 2.7 (Geometric Interpretation): The biconjugate f^{**} constructs the pointwise supremum (upper envelope) of all affine minorants of f . Specifically, the epigraph of f^{**} is the **closed convex hull** of the epigraph of f ,

$$\text{epi } f^{**} = \text{cl}(\text{conv}(\text{epi } f)).$$

Thus, f^{**} represents the "tightest" closed convex function that minorizes f .

2.1.1 Properties of the Biconjugate

Corollary 2.8 (Weak Duality): For any proper function f , the inequality $f^{**}(\mathbf{x}) \leq f(\mathbf{x})$ holds for all $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$.

Proof. Recall the **Fenchel-Young inequality**, which states that for any $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n$:

$$f^*(\mathbf{y}) + f(\mathbf{x}) \geq \mathbf{x}^T \mathbf{y}.$$

Rearranging terms yields:

$$\mathbf{x}^T \mathbf{y} - f^*(\mathbf{y}) \leq f(\mathbf{x}).$$

Since this inequality holds for all $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, it must also hold for the supremum over $\mathbf{y}$:

$$\sup_{\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n} (\mathbf{x}^T \mathbf{y} - f^*(\mathbf{y})) \leq f(\mathbf{x}).$$

By definition of the biconjugate, this is exactly $f^{**}(\mathbf{x}) \leq f(\mathbf{x})$. □

Theorem 2.9 (Fenchel-Moreau): Let $f : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R} \cup \{+\infty\}$ be a proper function. Then $f = f^{**}$ if and only if f is **closed** (lower semi-continuous) and **convex**.

Proof. The forward implication is immediate: since f^{**} is defined as the pointwise supremum of a family of affine functions, it is necessarily closed and convex. Thus, if $f = f^{**}$, f must share these properties.

For the reverse implication, assume f is proper, closed, and convex. By the weak duality lemma, $f^{**}(\mathbf{x}) \leq f(\mathbf{x})$ for all $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. It remains to show that $f(\mathbf{x}) \leq f^{**}(\mathbf{x})$.

We proceed by contradiction. Suppose there exists a point $\mathbf{x}_0 \in \mathbb{R}^n$ such that $f^{**}(\mathbf{x}_0) < f(\mathbf{x}_0)$. This implies that the point $(\mathbf{x}_0, f^{**}(\mathbf{x}_0)) \in \mathbb{R}^{n+1}$ lies strictly below the epigraph of f , denoted $\text{epi}(f)$. Since f is closed and convex, $\text{epi}(f)$ is a closed convex set.

By the **Strict Separating Hyperplane Theorem**, there exists a non-zero vector $(\mathbf{y}, \mu) \in \mathbb{R}^n \times \mathbb{R}$ and a scalar $\alpha \in \mathbb{R}$ such that:

$$\mathbf{y}^T \mathbf{x}_0 + \mu f^{**}(\mathbf{x}_0) > \alpha > \mathbf{y}^T \mathbf{x} + \mu t, \quad \forall (\mathbf{x}, t) \in \text{epi}(f).$$

Since $(\mathbf{x}, t) \in \text{epi}(f)$ allows t to be arbitrarily large, we must have $\mu \leq 0$ (otherwise the RHS would be unbounded).

Case 1: Non-vertical separation ($\mu < 0$) Divide the inequality by $-\mu > 0$. Let $\mathbf{m} = \mathbf{y}/(-\mu)$ and $c = \alpha/(-\mu)$. The separation becomes:

$$\mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x}_0 - f^{**}(\mathbf{x}_0) > c > \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x} - t, \quad \forall (\mathbf{x}, t) \in \text{epi}(f).$$

Setting $t = f(\mathbf{x})$ for $\mathbf{x} \in \text{dom}(f)$, we obtain $\mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x} - f(\mathbf{x}) < c$. Taking the supremum over $\mathbf{x}$:

$$f^*(\mathbf{m}) = \sup_{\mathbf{x}} (\mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x} - f(\mathbf{x})) \leq c.$$

However, the left side of the separation inequality yields $\mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x}_0 - c > f^{**}(\mathbf{x}_0)$. This implies that the affine function $h(\mathbf{z}) = \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{z} - f^*(\mathbf{m})$ satisfies:

$$h(\mathbf{x}_0) = \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x}_0 - f^*(\mathbf{m}) \geq \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x}_0 - c > f^{**}(\mathbf{x}_0).$$

This contradicts the definition of f^{**} as the supremum of *all* such affine minorants: $f^{**}(\mathbf{x}_0) \geq h(\mathbf{x}_0)$.

Case 2: Vertical separation ($\mu = 0$) If $\mu = 0$, the separation reduces to $\mathbf{y}^T \mathbf{x}_0 > \alpha > \mathbf{y}^T \mathbf{x}$ for all $\mathbf{x} \in \text{dom}(f)$. This means $\mathbf{x}_0$ is strictly separated from the domain of f in $\mathbb{R}^n$. Since f is proper and convex, it admits at least one affine minorant $g(\mathbf{z}) = \mathbf{a}^T \mathbf{z} - b \leq f(\mathbf{z})$. Consider the function $g_k(\mathbf{z}) = g(\mathbf{z}) + k(\mathbf{y}^T \mathbf{z} - \alpha)$. For $\mathbf{x} \in \text{dom}(f)$, since $\mathbf{y}^T \mathbf{x} < \alpha$, the term $k(\mathbf{y}^T \mathbf{x} - \alpha)$ is negative. Thus, $g_k(\mathbf{x}) \leq g(\mathbf{x}) \leq f(\mathbf{x})$ for all $k > 0$. This means g_k is an affine minorant of f for any k . At $\mathbf{x}_0$, however, $\mathbf{y}^T \mathbf{x}_0 > \alpha$, so the term $k(\mathbf{y}^T \mathbf{x}_0 - \alpha) \rightarrow +\infty$ as $k \rightarrow \infty$. Consequently, $f^{**}(\mathbf{x}_0) \geq g_k(\mathbf{x}_0) \rightarrow +\infty$. Since we assumed $f^{**}(\mathbf{x}_0) < f(\mathbf{x}_0) < \infty$ (if $f(\mathbf{x}_0) = \infty$ the inequality holds trivially), this yields a contradiction.

Thus, the assumption $f^{**}(\mathbf{x}_0) < f(\mathbf{x}_0)$ is false. We conclude $f = f^{**}$. $\square$

Remark 2.10: If f is convex but not closed, f^{**} is the lower semi-continuous closure of f . If f is not convex, f^{**} is the convex envelope of f .

3 Duality

Corollary 3.1: Let $f : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be a convex and differentiable function. For any $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{m} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, the following statements are equivalent:

1. $\mathbf{m} = \nabla f(\mathbf{x})$
2. $f(\mathbf{x}) + f^*(\mathbf{m}) = \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x}$

Proof. Recall the Fenchel-Young inequality, which states $f(\mathbf{x}) + f^*(\mathbf{m}) \geq \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x}$ for all $\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{m}$. We prove the equivalence of the equality condition and the gradient condition.

(1 $\implies$ 2): Assume $\mathbf{m} = \nabla f(\mathbf{x})$. Since f is convex and differentiable, the first-order condition for convexity states that for all $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n$,

$$f(\mathbf{y}) \geq f(\mathbf{x}) + \nabla f(\mathbf{x})^T (\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{x}).$$

Substituting $\mathbf{m} = \nabla f(\mathbf{x})$,

$$f(\mathbf{y}) \geq f(\mathbf{x}) + \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{y} - \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x}.$$

Rearranging terms to isolate $\mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{y} - f(\mathbf{y})$,

$$\mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{y} - f(\mathbf{y}) \leq \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x} - f(\mathbf{x}).$$

Taking the supremum of the left-hand side over all $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n$ yields the definition of the conjugate $f^*(\mathbf{m})$,

$$f^*(\mathbf{m}) = \sup_{\mathbf{y}} (\mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{y} - f(\mathbf{y})) \leq \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x} - f(\mathbf{x}).$$

This implies $f(\mathbf{x}) + f^*(\mathbf{m}) \leq \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x}$. Combining this with the Fenchel-Young inequality (which gives the reverse inequality $\geq$), we obtain equality,

$$f(\mathbf{x}) + f^*(\mathbf{m}) = \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x}.$$

(2 $\implies$ 1): Assume $f(\mathbf{x}) + f^*(\mathbf{m}) = \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x}$. Rearranging for $f(\mathbf{x})$,

$$f(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x} - f^*(\mathbf{m}).$$

By definition of the conjugate, $f^*(\mathbf{m}) \geq \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{y} - f(\mathbf{y})$ for any $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. Substituting this inequality into the equation above,

$$f(\mathbf{x}) \leq \mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{x} - (\mathbf{m}^T \mathbf{y} - f(\mathbf{y})).$$

Rearranging terms to compare $f(\mathbf{y})$ and $f(\mathbf{x})$,

$$f(\mathbf{y}) \geq f(\mathbf{x}) + \mathbf{m}^T (\mathbf{y} - \mathbf{x}).$$

This inequality holds for all $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. This is precisely the defining inequality for $\mathbf{m}$ being a subgradient of f at $\mathbf{x}$. Since f is differentiable, the subgradient is unique and equal to the gradient. Thus,

$$\mathbf{m} = \nabla f(\mathbf{x}).$$

□

Remark 3.2: Geometrically, this corollary asserts that the vector $\mathbf{m}$ defines a supporting hyperplane to the graph of f at $(\mathbf{x}, f(\mathbf{x}))$ if and only if Fenchel's inequality holds with equality.

3.1 Partial Minimization & Relation To Conjugate

Let $f : \mathbb{R}^n \times \mathbb{R}^k \rightarrow \mathbb{R} \cup \{+\infty\}$ be a function of two variables $(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y})$, where $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$ and $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^k$.

Definition 3.3 (Partial Minimization): The partial minimization of f with respect to $\mathbf{x}$ is the function $h : \mathbb{R}^k \rightarrow \mathbb{R} \cup \{+\infty\}$ defined as:

$$h(\mathbf{y}) = \inf_{\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n} f(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y})$$

Lemma 3.4 (Preservation of Convexity): If f is jointly convex in $(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y})$, then $h(\mathbf{y})$ is a convex function.